BETWEEN FACT AND FICTION

***G.N. Devy** shows us how the Mahabharata radicalises our notions of time while remaining timeless itself*

THE MAHABHARATA remains one of the most compelling stories ever told and, for most Indians, it provides a common cultural vocabulary that enriches their diverse linguistic ones. It is no surprise that G.N. Devy would turn his attention to it. Scholar of literature, collector of languages and stories, outspoken political activist, public intellectual—all of Prof. Devy's concerns and areas of expertise engage with the Mahabharata on many levels and in many different ways.

This slim volume, in which Devy meditates on the Mahabharata almost in a stream of consciousness, is a ready reckoner for much that the text addresses and some of the more interesting scholarship around it. Devy apprehends the Mahabharata as "simultaneously both" myth and as *itihasa* (which literally means 'and so it happened/ thus it was'). Via its central narrative and the hundreds of subplots that meander in and around it, Devy says that the Mahabharata takes us through the transition from pastoral Vedic society and its gods and religion to the time of republics and the emergence of new gods and powers. This is *itihasa*, "a manner of remembering the events in the past." Myth, on the hand, which the Mahabharata produces, Devy says, presents these events as if they "belong to a timeless and ever-present era", characters do not "operate within the reality of human space and time." The potent combination of a putative collective memory and the construction of *illo tempore* (when the gods were with us) is what makes the Mahabharata irresistible.

WHAT THE MAHABHARATA MEANS IS PROBABLY DETERMINED MORE BY OUR IMAGINATIONS THAN BY THE TEXT ITSELF

Devy argues that, through its characters and stories, the Mahabharata presents us with the idea of Time in the fullest possible way: as cosmic, mythical, historical and psychological. This allows the Mahabharata a unique way of presenting history "which is never a completely objective truth nor a complete fiction". Further, Devy says, ". . . the Mahabharata is yet not regarded by Indian people as a work of the past because it brings to them the Mahabharata method of perceiving the past".

A modest hundred thousand verses in length, the Mahabharata says of itself, "what is here can be found elsewhere, but what is not here is nowhere else." What the Mahabharata is about and what it means is probably determined more by our imaginations than by the text itself. For some, the text is a *dharma shastra*, telling us mortals how to choose between right and wrong. For others, it is a story about god acting in the world of humans and for still others, it is a grand narrative about a disputed throne and the desire for power that brings out the worst in all of us. And there are those who believe it is a story about "us" telling ourselves and Others who we are and how we came to be. The Mahabharata is commodious enough to allow all these readings and so, in the end, what one says about the Mahabharata is often more revealing about the commentator than it is about the text. ■

–Arshia Sattar

MAHABHARATA
The Epic and the Nation
by G.N. Devy
ALEPH BOOK COMPANY
₹499, 142 pages

